

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

STAR TURN
Mithun Chakraborty at a BJP rally in Mollarpur, Birbhum, on November 27

WEST BENGAL

BJP BANKS ON MITHUN MAGIC

paigner in the 2021 Bengal assembly election—he joined the BJP before the polls—yielded only mixed electoral dividends, his presence created enough photo-optics for the BJP. His head wrapped in a bandana, his eyes covered in big sun-shades and a long scarf thrown earthily around the neck like the humble *gamchha*, crowds in rural Bengal went berserk at some of his rallies. That positive impression—the sense that here at last was a leader readymade for the BJP, indubitably Bengali, unquestionably popular—did just about enough for the party to continue staying invested in him. If he didn't catch on like wild fire, he didn't get entirely stubbed out either. Out of 43 assembly seats in Bankura, Purulia, Paschim Medinipur and Jhargram—all districts with a substantial tribal population where Mithun campaigned—TMC got as many as 25 seats; the BJP ended up with 18.

Despite Mithun's inexperience as a politician, his enduring popularity amongst the masses, both rural and, crucially, urban, for over 40 years makes him a natural choice for a BJP bereft of any star power in Bengal. The party's hopes of roping in Sourav Ganguly were abandoned in the face of the cricket star's reluctance to join politics. Moreover, having Mithun as its face blunts the TMC's pet allegation of the BJP being a party of "outsiders". Surely, no one can brand Mithun Chakraborty, the man who defined the Bengali hero at one stage, an outsider. And he has always had a finger in the Bengali entertainment pie, including enormously popular reality shows. Over the decades, his charitable activities too have been well-known.

Mithun's naiveté may have aroused much mirth, but the way he's traversed a full pendulum swing of the political spectrum is serious: in his youth he dabbled in Naxalite politics, was close to the Left during its 34-year rule, had a brief dalliance with the TMC and was its Rajya Sabha MP from 2014 to 2016. He joined the BJP in March 2021.

THOUGH THE BJP IS BANKING ON MITHUN, IT IS ALSO HAVING A HARD TIME EXPLAINING HIS GAFFES

Other than Mithun, the BJP's most bankable star has been Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikary—aggressive and fearless in his ability to stand his ground against Mamata and her party's strongarm tactics. But he's all political brawn—and ultimately, will always be a man who crossed over. Mithun, with his attire, mannerisms and speeches replete with filmy dialogue, is a refreshing change. The BJP is hoping people will treasure their moment with the star at the time of pressing the EVM buttons.

The TMC, for its part, affects a great lack of concern about Mithun turning things around for its adversary. TMC spokesperson Kunal Ghosh recently reminded Mithun about the party's huge mandate only a year back. He also claimed Mithun joined the BJP for personal gain. Such pronouncements apart, the TMC is not leaving things to chance. The party had Mahua Moitra and Babul Supriya hold a rally in Purulia on December 1, a week after a well-received Mithun rally in the district. It's a Mithun show and, like everyone else, it's watching. ■